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Jean Baudrillard and the Death of God

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This essay considers Jean Baudrillard, the French sociologist and so-called “father of postmodernism,” as a theological thinker; more specifically, as a negative theological thinker. Though little attention is paid to the theological dimension of his work by his popular and critical readership, Baudrillard consistently reflects on contemporary culture in its negative relationship to the symbolic world of Judeo-Christian tradition, and this is a key to his significance as a post-Nietzschean thinker. Through the lens of his work, we are made to see that late-modern technological and neo-capitalistic culture is still fulfilling a theologically driven dynamic (one specifically Calvinistic in quality), only now it is doing so in a wholly negative or inverted phase, a radically *nihilistic* phase, in fact but one graced nonetheless with a certain ironic joy and humor. Like Nietzsche, Baudrillard is a comic writer, for whom tragedy and horror are mercifully refracted through comic wit. Even as he writes of a total subversion of reality in simulation, and of the human in the inhuman, Baudrillard’s writing is funny, provoking a last self-ironizing smile on the visage of the last man, even as his human body deconstructs into its inorganic components, and his human ideality vanishes into the “hyperreal” like the body of the Cheshire cat into its smile.

What becomes of the divinity when it reveals itself in icons, when it is multiplied in simulacra? Does it remain the supreme power that is simply incarnated in images as a visible theology? Or does it volatilize itself in the simulacra that, alone, deploy their power and pomp of fascination the visible machinery of icons substituted for the pure and intelligible Idea of God? [The Iconoclasts] predicted this omnipotence of simulacra, the faculty simulacra have of effacing God from the conscience of man.[^1]

> What were we doing when we unchained the earth from its sun? Whither is it moving now? Whither

Is "simulation," as Baudrillard depicts it, occupied with generating a surrogate to replace the

> Today abstraction is no longer that of the map, the double, the mirror, or the concept. . .

A "universe of simulation," when it reaches this stage, will have realized an infinite self-referentiality, having an endless self-processing as its sole reason for being, a self-contained, self-encoded, prospectively self-inscribed destiny fulfilling itself. This is perhaps

> Our obsession with 'real time', with the instantaneity of news, has a secret millenarianism

As God is the "original" of which *_imago Dei_* is the simulacrum, so eternity is the temporality

> Not any longer a fetishization of divinities, great ideas, or grand narratives, but of mini

More to the point, operative in this fetishishization Baudrillard sees a virulent nihilism at

Such is the logic of simulacra, it is no longer that of divine predestination, it is that of the precession of models, but it is just as inexorable. And it is because of this that events no longer have meaning: it is not that they are insignificant in themselves, it is that they

were preceded by the model, with which their processes only coincided. . . . Our time will never again be that of duration, our only temporality is that of the accelerated cycle and of recycling. . . . Our only culture in the end is that of . . . refining, cracking, breaking cultural molecules and of their recombination into synthesized products. (SS 55'56, 64)

Notes

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